

A Sanctuary In Microcosm, 5752 (1991)



From the writings and talks of the Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem M. Schneerson
From the Sichos in English Collection

To the exiles who sat by the waters of Babylon, dreaming of the despoiled Sanctuary in Jerusalem, the prophet Yechezkel brought this message of consolation: "Though I have scattered them throughout the lands, I will be for them a little sanctuary in the lands to which they have come."¹

Where is this sanctuary in microcosm?

"Rabbi Yitzchak holds: 'This refers to the synagogues and houses of study of Babylon.' Rabbi Eliezer holds: 'This refers to *Beis Rabbeinu*, the house of our teacher.'"²

* * *

Are these two interpretations opposed? What is the relationship between the miniature sanctuaries of Babylon and the *Beis HaMikdash* in Jerusalem? Since the Destruction, what is it that makes the Divine Presence choose to reside in particular sanctuaries? And how does this whole discussion in the *Talmud* find expression in our generation, on the eve of the Redemption?

These and many other, related questions are discussed and clarified in the essay before us, which is based on extracts from talks of the Rebbe *Shlita* on a number of occasions in recent years. It is particularly relevant today, when building operations are underway to expand the *beis midrash* of "770" considerably.

A Home Away from Home

One of the *chassidim* of the *Mitteler Rebbe*, Rabbi Avraham Dovber of Bobroisk, has described³ his first journey to Lubavitch, which took place when he was six years old. In vivid and powerful terms, he relates the moving moments he experienced, his encounters with the Rebbe and the chassidim.

Perhaps more than anything else, he was inspired by the intense joy that the chassidim felt there. When he asked his father to explain this phenomenon, his father spoke to him about the *Beis HaMikdash* in Jerusalem. And the boy was bewildered, for this made his question all the more powerful. How could the chassidim celebrate in this manner when the *Beis HaMikdash* was destroyed?

With the tact of a skilled educator, his father gave him time for the question to sink in, and then he explained in a calm but heartfelt tone:

Until G-d, blessed be He, shows His mercy to us, sends us the righteous redeemer... and rebuilds Jerusalem and the *Beis HaMikdash* for us..., *Lubavitch* is our Jerusalem, the Rebbe's *shul*, our *Beis*

HaMikdash,... and the Rebbe, the Holy Ark, containing the tablets of G-d's Torah.

These are sentiments which a father shared with his son at a time of deep feeling. Are they merely sentiments? Is there any basis in our Torah heritage for such feelings and such statements?

By the Waters of Babylon

Significantly, very similar ideas are expressed by the prophet Yechezkel when comforting the Jews with the Word of G-d, in the wake of the Babylonian exile:⁴ “So has G-d, the L-rd, spoken: ‘Though I have scattered them throughout the lands, I will be for them a sanctuary in microcosm in the lands where they have come.’ ”

When analyzing this verse, our Sages⁵ offer two interpretations of the term “sanctuary in microcosm”: “Rabbi Yitzchak holds: ‘This refers to the synagogues and houses of study in Babylon.’ Rabbi Eliezer holds: ‘This refers to *Beis Rabbeinu* [“the house of our master,” i.e., Rav⁶] in Babylon.’ ”

Similarly, our Sages state,⁷ “Wherever the Jews were exiled, the Divine Presence accompanied them.” This statement is problematic, for “the entire earth is filled with His glory.”⁸ There is no place where G-d is not found. What is meant by saying that the Divine Presence accompanies the Jews into exile?⁹

From the continuation of the passage, however, the intent becomes clear. The amoraim name certain synagogues in Babylon where there was an actual perception of the Divine Presence, resembling — albeit in microcosm — the manifestation of G-dliness in the *Beis HaMikdash*. Not only did G-d's Presence rest in these synagogues in a hidden manner, as it does throughout the world at large. In these particular places, G-d's Presence could actually be perceived.

The Torah: G-d's Haven in This World

Based on the above, it can be explained that the opinions of Rabbi Yitzchak and Rabbi Eliezer differ only in emphasis, not in principle. Rabbi Eliezer would also accept the premise that the Divine Presence rested in *all* synagogues in Babylon, and Rabbi Yitzchak would agree that the most evident and manifest expression of the Divine Presence was in *Beis Rabbeinu*.

What was unique about *Beis Rabbeinu*, Rav's house of study? It was the center of Torah law for the entire world. To explain: Commenting on the verse,¹⁰ “G-d loves the gates of Zion more than all the dwellings of Yaakov,” our Sages declare:¹¹ “G-d loves the gates of those who excel in the realm of halachah more than the synagogues and houses of study..., for from the day the *Beis HaMikdash* was destroyed, G-d has no [resting place] in this world other than the four cubits of halachah.”

Commenting on that passage, the *Maharasha* explains that the manifestation of the Divine Presence in the *Beis HaMikdash* was intrinsically related to the fact that it was the seat of the Sanhedrin, the ultimate halachic authority for the Jewish people. Similarly, since G-d's Presence is manifest in “the four cubits of *halachah*,” the place of the contemporary Torah authority is where the Divine Presence rests. Thus, the

expression “sanctuary in microcosm” is an apt description for *Beis Rabbeinu*, the source for instruction regarding our Torah conduct in exile.

The Return of the Divine Presence

The connection of the synagogues established in exile to the *Beis HaMikdash* is further emphasized by the continuation of the passage cited above:¹² “When they are redeemed in the future, the Divine Presence will accompany them.” The *Maharasha* explains this to mean that the Divine Presence will not remain in the places where it was revealed during the exile, but will return to *Eretz Yisrael* together with the Jewish people. Thus our Sages relate:¹³ “In the future, the synagogues and houses of study of [the diaspora] will be established in *Eretz Yisrael*.” Moreover, they will be positioned in direct proximity to the *Beis HaMikdash*, and the revelation of the Divine Presence in the *Beis HaMikdash* will permeate them as well.¹⁴

Furthermore, in the era immediately preceding the Redemption, there will be a foreglimpse of the *Beis HaMikdash* within the “sanctuary in microcosm” established in the exile. The Divine Presence will be revealed there, and from there will return with the Jewish people to *Eretz Yisrael* and to Jerusalem.¹⁵

A Beacon of Light

Based on the above, the *chassid's* memoirs related above take on a different dimension. In every generation there is a *Beis Rabbeinu*, “the house of our master,”¹⁶ a “sanctuary in microcosm” which responds to the urgent needs of the generation and diffuses Torah instruction throughout the world. Thus it serves as the place where the Divine Presence is revealed *par excellence*.

Since the Divine Presence is revealed for the sake of the Jewish people,¹⁷ it is in the house of the leader of the people as a whole, the leader of the generation who is “the heart of the generation,”¹⁸ that the Divine Presence becomes manifest during the time the Jews are in exile.

The above concept allows us to appreciate the uniqueness of the *Beis Rabbeinu* established by the Previous Rebbe in America. Today, the largest segment of the international Jewish community is found in America, and there is located the infrastructure for our generation's Torah leadership. This country was therefore chosen as the place for *Beis Rabbeinu*, the center for Torah instruction for the entire world.

Significantly, America has been described¹⁹ as “the lower hemisphere.” The Torah was given in the upper hemisphere and it is our task to spread the Torah throughout the world, elevating the totality of our existence. It is this service of — to borrow an expression of the *Tzemach Tzedek's*²⁰ — “Making *this* place *Eretz Yisrael*,” which prepares us for the age when “*Eretz Yisrael* will spread out throughout the entire world,”²¹ in the Era of the Redemption.

The Challenge Facing Our Generation

The connection of the Previous Rebbe's *Beis Rabbeinu* to the Redemption is reflected in the very name of the building — “770,” for that is numerically equivalent to the Hebrew word פּרַצַת, meaning “break through.” On the verse concerning the birth of Peretz, the progenitor of the *Mashiach*,²² פּרַצַת עַלֵיךְ פֶּרֶץ, our Sages

comment,²³ “This refers to the *Mashiach*, as it is written,²⁴ “The one who breaks through (הפורץ) shall ascend before them.” This is the task of *Mashiach* — to break through the barriers of exile and spread holiness throughout the world, as it is written,²⁵ “And you shall spread out vigorously (*Ufaratzta*) westward, eastward, northward and southward.”

Furthermore, the number 770 is a multiple of the number seven.²⁶ Our Sages relate,²⁷ “All the sevenths are cherished,” and it has been explained²⁸ that the preciousness of the seventh is reflected in the task of drawing the Divine Presence down to the earth, so that the Divine Presence becomes manifest as it was manifest in the Sanctuary. This is also the task of our generation, the seventh generation — to hasten the coming of the Era of the Redemption, the era in which G-d will again reveal His Presence in the world openly, and not merely in microcosm.

This is not a promise of the distant future, but an imminent reality. We are on the threshold of the Redemption and indeed, in the process of crossing that threshold.²⁹ Our Rabbis relate³⁰ that in every generation, there is a potential *Mashiach*. This means that *Mashiach* is among us, waiting for us to recognize his mission and create a climate in the world that will allow it to be fulfilled.

May this take place in the immediate future and then, together with all the synagogues and houses of study in the diaspora, the “sanctuaries in microcosm,” we will all proceed to *Eretz Yisrael*, to Jerusalem, and to the *Beis HaMikdash*.

Talks by the Rebbe: י"ט כסלו, ה'תשנ"ב

Lubavitcher Rebbe

FOOTNOTES

1. *Yechezkel* 11:16.

2. *Megillah* 29a.

3. *HaTamim*, Vol. II, p. 124-6.

4. *Yechezkel* 11:16.

5. *Megillah* 29a.

6. Rashi, loc. cit.

7. *Megillah*, loc. cit.

8. *Yeshayahu* 6:3.

9. See the commentary of the Maharasha, *Megillah*, loc. cit.

10. *Tehillim* 87:2.

11. *Berachos* 8a.

12. *Megillah*, loc. cit.

13. Ibid.

14. *Maharasha*, loc. cit. On this basis, the *Maharasha* explains a statement of the *Midrash* that in the Era of the Redemption, the *Beis HaMikdash* will encompass the totality of Jerusalem. Since all the synagogues and houses of study in the diaspora will be included in the *Beis HaMikdash*, its area will be the size of the entire city of Jerusalem.

15. On this basis, we can understand a problematic aspect of the now renowned passage in the *Yalkut Shimoni* (Vol. II, sec. 499) which foretells the era immediately preceding *Mashiach's* coming. That passage relates that *Mashiach* will “stand on the roof of the *Beis HaMikdash* and proclaim to the Jewish people, ‘Humble ones: The time of your Redemption has come.’ ”

That statement is difficult to comprehend. As the *Rambam* writes (*Mishneh Torah, Hilchos Melachim 11:4*), the construction of the *Beis HaMikdash* is one of the final stages of the Redemption. It would thus appear that well before the *Beis HaMikdash* will have been rebuilt, *Mashiach* will have had to inform the Jewish people of their Redemption.

Based on the above, however, this passage can be understood: *Mashiach* will stand on the roof of the “sanctuary in microcosm” that exists in the diaspora and communicate his message of redemption to the Jewish people. (This is alluded to by the expression “the roof of the *Beis HaMikdash*.” As the *Rambam* writes in *Hilchos Beis HaBechirah*, the roof of the *Beis HaMikdash* was not consecrated. This is an allusion to the diaspora, which does not have the quality of revealed holiness possessed by *Eretz Yisrael*.)

16. This is alluded to in *Rashi's* explanation of the term *Beis Rabbeinu* as referring to the house of Rav. The name “Rav” implies that this distinction was given to him — and his house — not because of his personal qualities, but because of his position as the Torah leader of the Jews of his generation.

17. This is alluded to in the interpretation of *Shmos 25:8*, “And you shall make Me a sanctuary and I will dwell within.” The *Shelah* (69a) notes that rather than write בתוכו — “within it,” the verse uses the expression בתוכם — “within them,” implying that the fundamental revelation of G-d's Presence will take place within every individual Jew. See the English translation of the *maamarim* entitled *Basi LeGani* (Kehot, Sichos In English): the *maamar* of 5710, ch. 1.

18. See *Rambam, Hilchos Melachim 3:6*. See also *Bamidbar Rabbah 19:28*: “The leader [of the generation] represents the entire nation.”

19. See *Igros Kodesh* (Letters) of the Previous Rebbe, Vol. II, p. 492 ff.

20. *Ibid.*, Vol. I, p. 485. See the essay, “Make This Place *Eretz Yisrael*,” published by Sichos In English Vol. 49, pgs. 73-78.

21. *Yalkut Shimoni*, Vol. II, sec. 503.

22. *Bereishis 38:29*.

23. *Aggadas Bereishis*, ch. 63.

24. *Michah 2:13*.

25. *Bereishis 28:15*.

26. It combines ten times seven and one hundred times seven. The *Kabbalah* teaches that we have ten faculties of the soul and all of these vital faculties are interrelated. (Thus ten times ten equals 100.) In this context, the number 770 reflects how the number seven has permeated every dimension of the human personality.

27. *Vayikra Rabbah 29:11*.

28. *Basi LeGani 5710, Basi LeGani 5711*.

29. See the essay entitled “On the Threshold of the Redemption,” *Sichos In English* Vol. 49, pgs. 66-72.

³⁰. See the *Chasam Sofer*, Responsa on *Choshen Mishpat*, Vol. VI, Responsum 98; *S'dei Chemed*, *Pe'as HaSadeh*, *Maareches Alef*, principle 70. See also above the essay entitled “*Mashiach* in Every Generation.”

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A free translation from a talk of the Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem M. Schneerson, of righteous memory.

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